

Travelling to Greece, Crete & Villa Koukouvayia Some FAQs

Answers to some Cretan/Greek Travel & Program FAQs



- 1) **Beware of Multiple Spellings:** We're not sure about other languages, but the attempt to transliterate Greek into English has created a rich tradition of confusing multi-spellings for the same places—a cute feature until you book the wrong airport (see below.) Irakleio is often spelled Heraklion, with both names either showing or hiding a final 'n.' Xania is usually rendered as Chania, sometimes Canea, and—far more rarely—Hania, the only spelling which remotely communicates the city's actual pronunciation. And that's just for the larger cities—the same can apply to the villages. So be careful when booking flights, buses, ferries, etc.
- 2) **Money & Currency:** Greek currency is in Euros. ATMs provide Euro withdrawals from your bank with smaller fees than airport or tourist exchange desks. ATMs are at all airports, and once you're here, you'll find them in all towns.
- 3) **Mobile Service:** Greece has two main carriers, Cosmote & Vodafone. Both usually let your current SIM roam & make calls. For in-Greece calls, SIMs are available at Athens airport or here (cheaper) once you're settled in. So, avoid SIMs from dubious sellers like kiosks or taxis.
- 4) **Flights:** It can be difficult to fly to Crete 'direct' except from Athens. (And if coming from the US, note that direct flights to Athens are pricier than those with Euro stops.) Both Athens (ATH/Venizelos) & Xania (Pronounced "Hahn-YAH", often spelled Chania, Hania & sometimes Canea, but always with the airport code CHQ) are simple, easy airports. And remember it's Crete not Cyprus. (Yes, someone did that.) And remember, it's CHQ (Xania) not HER (Herakleion/Irakleio), the latter of which is on the far side of the (very large) island. (And yes, someone did that, too. Us!)

But it is worth noting that sometimes, better flight pricing and/or itineraries are available to Irakleio/HER and will make the extra 2+ hours of driving worth it. And we can provide directions from either airport.

5) **Ferries:** Many people ask about the (rather romantic) notion of coming to Crete by ferry. The ferry is an amazing experience, and I'm glad I've done it enough times to NEVER do it again. It's long, subject to weather delays/cancellations, and unless you pay for an overnight cabin, you will most likely end up sleeping on the (interior) decks with the other 3,000 people who couldn't afford (or couldn't reserve—they're limited) a cabin. The scene feels like a refugee center two days after a natural disaster hits, with everyone wearing the same scent from Estee Lauder: "Eau de Dead Goat."

Most importantly it will eat up at least a day of your itinerary.

The other option is the Dolphin (i.e. 'Fast') ferry. This will not eat up a day of your itinerary, in fact 'eating' anything for you will not likely happen for three days after you stumble onto dry land, fall to your knees and kiss the dock at the trip's end. These things look like James Bond villains' boats, and travel over the sea at incredible speeds. Try to imagine being in a burlap sack tied behind Lewis Hamilton's rear suspension during the F1 race at Monaco, but if the circuit was still paved with charmingly large cobblestones. It really wouldn't matter if there was a large lounge chair or stadium sized flat-screen TV playing non-stop Rap-Music Booty-Call videos in the burlap sack, would it?

Nor does it matter if you're a person who can claim "I never get sick at sea," unless you're also a person who can claim "I never get sick watching 75 other people get sick at sea, quite often right in front of me, and quite often onto me."

And all kidding aside, the two final blows to ferry travel (either the slow or fast options) is that they have the most arcane, incomprehensible online ticketing system I've ever seen; and it will be almost impossible to in any way speed your departure from the mainland to Crete vs. the late flight at which you were originally balking. The ferries to Crete tend to be overnight, and the ground transport time between Athens airport and Piraeus (the usual ferry port, although there might be a ferry out of Rafina, which is closer to the airport) is long and not cheap. So, if you were considering the ferry as a 'quicker' option, you won't likely advance your departure time. And if you were thinking to do your wallet a favor, when everything's settled, you won't really avoid the costs of a flight.

Which leaves the only reason to take the ferry the chance to have an 'authentic' Greek travel experience; or, if you're extremely lonely, to acquire the following charming answer to the future question of: "Mommy, how did you meet Daddy?"

"Well, dear, even though Mommy was not a refugee and had a passport and citizenship to a first-world country, she was on a steamer sleeping on a floor next to a hundred complete strangers who were snoring and needed shaves when the ship took a queer swell on her starboard beam and rolled hard to port. One of those strangers' arms fell over me; and that was Daddy. And nine months later, you were born!"

- 6) **Car Rentals:** Insurance coverage and law require International Driver's Licenses, usually easy to get—in the U.S. at AAA offices or online. (Rental car places sometimes don't ask for them, and sometimes insist, so be prepared.)

If pre-booking, ask for "airport pickup and drop off" so an agent meets you when you leave Baggage-Claim. This is by far the easiest, and most efficient way to pick up (and drop off) a rental car. Before you release the agent, remember that, historically, Cretan rentals take a beating and get little service. Check tires, lights, etc., and check the gas tank. The rule "Leave tank as found," often results in an empty tank, and will burn you if you pick up late and gas stations are closed.

Or the opposite. The quaint history of renting a car that's been beaten like an island mule is now changing, sometimes to the renter's detriment. We hear more and more stories where rental car companies are recording 'damage' on returned cars in a way that comes suspiciously close to checking for simple 'use.' If the agent insists on reviewing the car with you at delivery, do so, and take pictures of any, even slight damage, and describe the damage on the contract—especially if the agent does not note that damage first.

Also, on the rental contract you will most likely sign a promise not to take the car 'off-road.' Quite surprisingly, this can occur even for actual 'off-road' rentals like Jeeps and other 4x4s and SUVs, which you've chosen precisely so you can get 'off-road.' Keep in mind that what 'off-road' can mean to the rental company is just a 'dirt' road, even a well-established and public way—of which Crete has many. That description includes the road to Balos which almost every tourist in their rental car takes. Keep that in mind as you explore the island, where many of the roads are well-graded, easily travelled, but dirt. And if you do have a problem or flat, hire a private tow-company to get you back to the paved section, and then call the rental car company.

And be aware: Like Olympic runners with lousy shoes, rental car SUVs and 4x4s with lousy tires can neither go where nor do what they were designed to go and do; and rental car companies rarely pay the cost of fitting those vehicles with good, off-road tires. So, while it's tempting to rent one of these vehicles and suddenly believe that you're George of the Jungle or King of the Wildebeests, be careful about dashing truly 'off-the-road' and following some rutted tractor path to a secluded beach. You may end up stuck there and then, like Tom Hanks, have no one to talk to for years (your passengers will not be talking to you any longer) but a volleyball.

- 7) **Buses:** Buses are frequent, cheap (€5-€8) and go everywhere on the island. They are not fast, but they're not a bad option to get around for anyone who wants to avoid the hassle of having/parking/gassing a car, or for the young, the broke, or the simply adventurous who have not rented a car and don't want to pay money for a taxi. [Schedules](#) are easily found online (in English) and easy to read understand. And if you're coming to Villa K by bus, take the airport bus to the Xania bus terminal, (usually runs each ½ hour) then the Kissamos/Kastelli bus (usually hourly) from Chania. Ask the driver to drop you off in Kaloudiana (Kah-lou-thee-ahh-NAH). Once in Kaloudiana, you are 1.2 km from the house. You can use the directions we gave you to walk (if you don't have a lot of luggage); grab Theodoris if he's in his cab in the town square, or call us and we'll usually be able to come down and pick you up.

- 8) **Taxis**: For long trips (like the airport to Kaloudiana/Villa K.) are expensive—about €80 now, without tip. But for quick, short rides off the bus routes, they're inexpensive and efficient.
- 9) **Driving in Crete**: In most cases, a person's capacity to comfortably drive a car involves whether they can drive a standard transmission or need an automatic. In Crete, what's more important is if they have a fear of heights. Cretan topography is dramatic, and—speaking in geological time-frames—almost fluid. There are roads everywhere, but other than a 2km stretch of National Highway along the (relatively) flat northern coast, the roads must bend, rise and fall with the landscape, and they do all three with a passion, often without guardrails. (Just as people living at the equator don't have words for 'snow,' Cretan Greek doesn't seem to have a word for 'guard-rail'.)

But every price has its rewards, and those same roads, when driven with courage and care, will take you to places and views otherwise available only in dreams.

- 10) **Weather & Clothing**: Regardless of seasonal expectations, even a summer visit may provide a chance to visit the chilly peaks of a mountaintop, and even a January day might suggest a plunge in the sea. And so, while it's rarely cold or rainy during summer months, you should bring at least a windbreaker to prepare for the odd day or excursion that falls outside the normal. Likewise, while November thru Feb can be chilly with truly wet days, those periods often alternate with clear, warm skies that call for simple shorts, tee-shirts & even a bathing suit. And for all months, you should be prepared to meet the Mediterranean sun, a gorgeous seductive siren on calendar photos, but a bit harsher in person.
- 11) **Health Care Options**: We've experienced excellent service here, both for routine care and emergency surgeries and in both private clinics and public hospitals. Most private clinics coordinate with most insurers. For immediate care an emergency clinic is 5 minutes from Villa Koukouvayia, and a private clinic ½ hour away in Xania.
- 12) **Greek/Cretan Cuisine & Dietary Preferences**: Cretan food is healthy, almost always locally sourced, and rich in vegetable dishes. However, excepting the most expensive and chic restaurants far from our neighborhood, they've not cared to master the political nature of menus. In other words, if you're a vegetarian, you'll find many nutritious dishes to please your palette. If you're a vegan, however, or a vegetarian expecting restaurants to use separate utensils for meat vs. vegetable dishes, that will be harder to find. You will almost always succeed in finding a wonderful meal, but prepare for a few political imperfections.
- 13) **Dining Out in Crete/Greece**: There is a familial and generous nature to Crete's restaurants and tavernas that most people love because it results in food that is cheap, plentiful, and truly "home"-made. But this quality also results in food served "family style" with the table rather than the individuals ordering. We've noticed this throws off mostly our American friends, who share the cultural expectation of having their "own" proprietary dish, and are not accustomed to collective ordering & dining. In our experience, however, the art & human symphony of sharing a meal is far richer than simply sharing a table. It's a wonderful exercise in community & reward, and one of many examples where Greek chaos reveals a joyous & organic logic. And if you demand that 2nd-language waiters split bills into tiny fragments, you'll not only confuse them, you'll look weird.